IN THE UNITED STATES DISTRICT COURT
FOR THE WESTERN DISTRICT OF TENNESSEE
WESTERN DIVISION

CHRISTY CORAN P/K/A "GANGSTA GOLD" AND LATONYA PIERCE P/K/A "MC MONEY", Plaintiffs, v. CARLOS DUAN PERRY P/K/A DJ SOUND, Defendant.	Case No._____ JURY DEMAND

VERIFIED COMPLAINT

Plaintiffs Christy Coran p/k/a "Gangsta Gold" ("Coran" or "Gangsta Gold") and Latonya Pierce p/k/a "MC Money" ("Pierce" or "MC Money") (collectively, "Plaintiffs"), by and through their undersigned counsel, bring this Complaint against Defendant Carlos Duan Perry p/k/a "DJ Sound" ("Perry" or "DJ Sound") and state as follows:

NATURE OF THE ACTION

1. This action concerns music that MC Money and Gangsta Gold created in Memphis during the 1990s and the money it began generating decades later. Plaintiffs wrote and performed original lyrics and vocals on Da Hard Ov Frayser (the "Album"). Defendant Carlos Duan Perry, professionally known as DJ Sound, produced and recorded the Album. Plaintiffs were not Perry's employees, signed no work-made-for-hire agreement or assignment, and received the master materials to manufacture and sell the Album for their own account.

2. When contemporary phonk artists began sampling this music, Perry positioned

himself as the catalog's gatekeeper. He licensed Plaintiffs' songs and recordings, collected fees, publishing interests, and royalties, and authorized a commercial reissue of their Album without disclosing the complete terms or accounting for Plaintiffs' shares. One known 2024 transaction covered at least thirty sample clearances and included a $100,000 master-use fee plus a fifty-percent publishing interest in thirty new songs.

3. Perry eventually acknowledged that the catalog was making money and that Plaintiffs were entitled to payment. He made partial payments and participated in an accounting, but the process ended before he disclosed all relevant transactions, identified what he had received, or paid Plaintiffs the balance. Plaintiffs bring this action to establish their rights and recover the proceeds Perry received from exploiting their music.

4. Plaintiffs believe the partial payments represent only a small fraction of what they are owed and presently estimate their damages at no less than $500,000 and likely substantially more, subject to the accounting and discovery sought here.

PARTIES

5. Plaintiff Christy Coran p/k/a Gangsta Gold is an individual residing in Shelby County, Tennessee.

6. Plaintiff Latonya Pierce p/k/a MC Money is an individual residing in Shelby County, Tennessee.

7. Upon information and belief, Defendant Carlos Duan Perry p/k/a DJ Sound resides in Shelby County, Tennessee.

JURISDICTION AND VENUE

8. This Court has subject-matter jurisdiction under 28 U.S.C. §§ 1331, 1338(a), and

1338(b), and under 15 U.S.C. § 1121, because Plaintiffs assert claims under the Copyright Act, 17 U.S.C. §§ 101, 103(b), and 201(a); the Declaratory Judgment Act, 28 U.S.C. §§ 2201–2202; and the Lanham Act, 15 U.S.C. § 1125(a)(1)(A). This Court has original jurisdiction under 28 U.S.C. § 1338(b) over Plaintiffs' claims of unfair competition, which are joined with substantial and related claims under the copyright and trademark laws.

9. This Court has supplemental jurisdiction over Plaintiffs' Tennessee-law claims under 28 U.S.C. § 1367(a) because those claims form part of the same case or controversy as Plaintiffs' federal copyright and Lanham Act claims.

10. Venue is proper in this District under 28 U.S.C. §§ 1391(b) and 1400(a) because Perry resides and may be found in this District and a substantial part of the events and omissions giving rise to Plaintiffs' claims occurred here.

11. Assignment to the Western Division is proper because the parties reside in Shelby County and the acts and omissions alleged in this Complaint occurred principally in Shelby County, Tennessee.

FACTUAL ALLEGATIONS

A. Plaintiffs Created and Released Da Hard Ov Frayser

12. MC Money and Gangsta Gold are Memphis recording artists and songwriters. They contributed original lyrics, verses, vocal performances, and other original expression to recordings released by or associated with DJ Sound and the Frayser Click.

13. Perry is a Memphis producer, recording engineer, performer, and organizing figure associated with the Frayser Click. He has publicly described the group's collaborative process: Perry created, selected, sampled, arranged, or assembled production elements; recorded and mixed the sessions; and sometimes supplied hooks, vocals, or lyrics. Perry further explained

that he would “make the beat first” and then allow participating artists to “come back [and] put their stuff to it.”[1] The participating artists supplied their own lyrics, verses, and vocal performances.

14. Plaintiffs worked with Perry in that manner. They wrote and finalized their own lyrics and verses, chose their phrasing and delivery, and controlled the expression they contributed. Perry did not write or rewrite their lyrics or hire them simply to perform material he authored. The parties intended to combine Plaintiffs’ contributions with Perry’s production and, where applicable, material supplied by other artists.

15. Perry has publicly described Da Hard Ov Frayser as the album he made “for MC Money and Gangsta Gold” and, more specifically, as Plaintiffs’ “solo tape.” Perry further acknowledged that, after completing the album, he gave Plaintiffs the master tape so they could manufacture and sell their own copies, telling them to “go get y’all money.” These statements and actions objectively manifested Perry’s contemporaneous understanding that Da Hard Ov Frayser was Plaintiffs’ album, not merely a DJ Sound compilation on which Plaintiffs appeared, and that Plaintiffs were entitled to possess and commercially exploit the completed album for their own benefit.[2]

16. The cassette artwork reflected those separate roles. It prominently identified MC Money and Gangsta Gold as the recording artists and used the phrase “DJ Sound Presents” to identify Perry’s role in presenting and producing the Album.

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[1] See Al Kapone, Memphis Rap History with the Frayser Legend DJ SOUND Hosted by Al Kapone, YouTube, at 19:27–20:22 (June 7, 2026), https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=VR-iLQLWzF4.

[2] See Tha Gat Dam Channel, DJ Sound Interview: He Discusses Recording Yo Gotti, the Frayser Click, & the Phonk Movement!, YouTube, at 18:01–19:22 (Aug. 12, 2022), https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xma2ZLYWEC4.

17. Plaintiffs manufactured cassette copies, sold them hand to hand in Memphis, placed them in local record stores, and kept the proceeds. Perry did not administer those sales, demand an accounting, claim a share, or say the sales were unauthorized.

18. The parties created the Album within the informal environment of the underground Memphis rap scene of the 1990s. They did not use written artist or producer agreements, split sheets, or a centralized royalty-accounting system.

19. Neither Plaintiff was Perry's employee. Neither signed a work-made-for-hire agreement, assigned her copyright interests to Perry, or gave him an exclusive license. No written instrument gave Perry exclusive ownership or control of Plaintiffs' interests.

20. Perry retained copies of original tapes, multitrack recordings, and other source materials. He has publicly described using retained source recordings to isolate instrumentals and a cappella vocals, remaster old recordings, and create additional versions. His possession of those physical materials did not reflect any agreement that he alone owned the copyrights embodied in them.

21. Plaintiffs contributed original lyrics, songwriting, recorded vocals, or other copyrightable expression to each of the following tracks on the album: a. "Ridgecrest Anthem"; b. "Down With the Click"; c. "Glock-Tight Smoked-Out"; d. "Ridgecrest Taking Over"; e. "Dead in His Tracks"; f. "I Just Need Yo Cheese"; g. "Load Da Ammo"; h. "Shouts Out"; and i. "Bout Our Hogg."

22. Upon information and belief, Plaintiffs' creative contributions are also embodied in numerous additional DJ Sound and Frayser Click Works that have been sampled, repurposed, reissued, licensed, incorporated into later recordings, or otherwise commercially exploited. Those Works include, but are not limited to, "Kickin N Doors," "Cross the Click,"

“Broken Halo,” “Choky Choke,” “Watch Out for Da Click,” “Real Niggaz,” “Broke Niggaz,” “Fuckin Wit Da Killaz,” “Stalkin’ With Da Yalk,” and “Frayser Is My Area.”

23. As used below, the “Works” are the musical compositions and sound recordings to which MC Money, Gangsta Gold, or both contributed original expression for inclusion in the completed work. “Plaintiff Material” means a Plaintiff’s original lyrics, songwriting, recorded vocal performances, and corresponding ownership interests embodied in a Work. “Covered Exploitations” means any reissue, license, clearance, settlement, distribution, administration, or other commercial use of a Work or Plaintiff Material, whether used directly or through one or more intermediate recordings. “Exploitation Proceeds” means all cash and non-cash consideration paid, credited, conveyed, or payable from Covered Exploitations, including license fees, settlements, royalties, advances, reissue income, publishing interests, royalty participations, and receivables. “Transaction Records” means the agreements, registrations, schedules, claim files, correspondence, statements, performing rights organization records, payment records, and other documents needed to identify Covered Exploitations and trace the resulting Exploitation Proceeds.

B. The Phonk Market Made the Music Commercially Valuable

24. Decades after the Album’s original release, recordings associated with DJ Sound and the Frayser Click experienced an unexpected commercial resurgence. Contemporary phonk artists and producers began sampling underground Memphis recordings from the 1990s.

25. Modern recordings incorporated material from Works containing Plaintiffs’ lyrics, voices, and performances. In many instances, Plaintiffs’ material was the passage selected and repeated in the new recording.

26. The licensing market was largely reactive. Artists and producers often released

sampled tracks before seeking clearance. Uses were scattered across global platforms, and the source audio was frequently slowed, sped up, pitch-shifted, filtered, chopped, looped, or otherwise altered.

27. Some uses were also layered. A Work containing Plaintiffs' material might be sampled into an intermediate recording that was later sampled again. Each layer could involve different contributors, but the additional sampling did not eliminate Plaintiffs' interests in their preexisting material.

28. Perry has publicly described finding one sampled track on a platform such as YouTube, reviewing other releases by the same artist, and following those leads to additional uses. Perry held himself out as the person authorized to clear older DJ Sound and Frayser Click material and directed users to obtain clearance through him. Upon information and belief, Perry then retained counsel who further investigated the sample chain and developed a process for identifying and tracking potential infringement claims.

29. Upon information and belief, Perry then settled many of these potential infringement claims with artists, record labels, and music publishers in exchange for: (a) a share of master revenue, paid through either a lump-sum buyout or a continuing royalty stream with a catch-up payment for past royalties; and (b) a percentage ownership interest in the copyright in the new composition. The transactions identified below are representative, not exhaustive. Perry and his counterparties possess the records needed to identify the remaining transactions and determine what Perry received.

C. One Transaction Included a $100,000 Fee and Half the Publishing in Thirty New Songs

30. Upon information and belief, in or around February 2024, Perry, in his individual capacity, signed a written agreement with WHY Z MUSIC LLC covering at least

thirty sample clearances for recordings by LXST CXNTURY and RHODAMINE.

31. The source material included multiple Works embodying Plaintiffs' writing and performances, including "I Just Need Yo Cheese" (five uses); "Load Da Ammo" (four uses); "Ridgecrest Taking Over" (four uses); "Down With the Click" (three uses); and "Bout Our Hogg" (one use).

32. Upon information and belief, representative recordings covered by the agreement include LXST CXNTURY's "Space Attack," "War," "Kyoto," and "Lunacy." These recordings do not merely sample tracks with which Plaintiffs were associated. They reproduce and repeat Plaintiffs' actual vocal performances and, where those vocals embody Plaintiffs' lyrics or songwriting, their interests in the underlying compositions.

33. For example, "Space Attack" contains MC Money's vocals from approximately 0:20 to 1:33 and Gangsta Gold's vocals from approximately 1:34 to 2:01. "War" uses MC Money's vocals from the beginning through approximately 1:46; "Kyoto" uses Gangsta Gold's vocals from approximately 0:14 to 2:22; and "Lunacy" uses both Plaintiffs' vocals in multiple extended passages.

34. Upon information and belief, Perry purported to grant retroactive and prospective, perpetual, worldwide licenses covering the sampled sound recordings and compositions and to release claims arising from the licensees' prior uses.

35. The stated consideration included a $100,000 nonrecoupable master-use fee and a fifty-percent publishing interest in each covered new composition and its versions, together with administration and collection rights.

36. Upon information and belief, WHY Z MUSIC LLC and the licensees paid or credited that consideration, continued exploiting the covered recordings, and recognized or

registered Perry's claimed publishing interests. Perry received or controlled all or a material part of the cash consideration and the publishing interests and income.

37. Perry did not recognize any share of those interests as belonging to Plaintiffs, compensate them for the portions attributable to their material, or provide the agreement, proof of payment, registrations, royalty records, or allocation methodology.

38. Upon information and belief, the publishing interests granted to Perry have separately yielded royalty payments in excess of $150,000.

Perry's Relationship with the Black 17 Record Label and Publishing Affiliate

39. Upon information and belief, Perry licensed numerous Works to Black 17 and to artists releasing through Black 17. Perry then entered into a publishing administration deal under which Black 17 would administer his entire copyright catalog as his exclusive licensing agent. Black 17 Media serves as Perry's publishing administrator and also operates as a record label and distributor in the modern phonk market.[3]

40. Black 17 publishes and distributes MC ORSEN's "Warning" and the separately released "Warning (Sped Up)" and "Warning (Slowed)." Each version samples "Glock-Tight Smoked-Out," a Work to which both Plaintiffs contributed.

41. By way of example, the sampled passages repeatedly feature Gangsta Gold's recorded voice. Her vocals appear in "Warning" at approximately 0:15 to 0:47 and 1:20 to 1:35, with corresponding passages appearing in the sped-up and slowed versions.

42. Upon information and belief, "Warning" and its separately released versions

[3] See Andrea Prada Bianchi, The Soundtrack of the Doomscroll Generation? It's Phonk., N.Y. Times (Feb. 23, 2026), https://www.nytimes.com/2026/02/23/arts/music/phonk-youtube-tiktok-music.html (describing Black 17's role in clearing and monetizing phonk recordings incorporating Memphis rap samples and reporting that its top 250 songs amassed more than one trillion streams and generated over $140 million in creator payments).

alone have generated well over one billion streams worldwide.

43. Upon information and belief, Perry, Black 17, or both entered into, administered, or benefited from licenses, clearances, settlements, publishing arrangements, or distribution agreements concerning "Warning." Perry has not disclosed the complete terms, accounted for the resulting fees and income, or paid Plaintiffs all amounts attributable to their Work.

44. Furthermore, upon information and belief, Perry licensed recordings and compositions from the Album to record labels and publishers for use in dozens of other recordings, including KSLV Noah, "Midnight Shift"; Ghostface Playa, "Deadline"; ONIMANXD, "Riders"; Mista Playa, "Enemy and Revenge" and "Enemy and Revenge 2"; DVRST, "Dream Space" and "Dream Space Sped Up"; DVRST, "Transition to Reality"; and Ghostface Playa, "Daredevil."

45. Upon information and belief, in exchange for these licenses, Perry received one or more of the following: substantial cash payments, rights to ongoing master royalties, and shares of the copyrights in new compositions embodying the samples.

D. Perry Admitted He Owed Plaintiffs Money but Did Not Explain His Payments

46. Shortly after the WHY Z MUSIC transaction, Perry told Plaintiffs that their older recordings were generating money through modern licensing, settlements, and other uses. He did not claim that Plaintiffs owned nothing. He acknowledged that they retained economic interests and were entitled to payment.

PRAYER FOR RELIEF

WHEREFORE, Plaintiffs demand judgment against Perry and respectfully request that

the Court grant the following relief, without duplicative recovery for the same injury under more than one Count:

(a) A declaration that Plaintiffs are joint authors and copyright co-owners of the applicable Works; that neither transferred her interests to Perry; that incorporation of Plaintiff Material into another recording did not transfer or extinguish those rights; and such further relief as is necessary under 28 U.S.C. § 2202;

(b) Actual and compensatory damages, including unpaid amounts and ownership interests due under the parties' agreements and applicable law, damages caused by Perry's fiduciary breaches, and damages caused by the unauthorized use of Plaintiffs' names;

(c) In the alternative, restitution, disgorgement, recovery of money had and received, and appropriate relief concerning identifiable property obtained for or attributable to Plaintiffs;

(d) A complete accounting of all Covered Exploitations and resulting Exploitation Proceeds, including direct and intermediate uses, cash and non-cash consideration, publishing interests, registrations, receipts, deductions, receivables, and prior payments;

(e) Determination and payment or conveyance of the consideration due to each Plaintiff, including assignment and conveyance of each Plaintiff's proportionate share of the publishing interests, royalty participations, and other non-cash consideration obtained through Covered Exploitations, with credit for prior partial payments;

(f) Appropriate prospective relief requiring Perry to disclose future Covered

Exploitations and remit the portions due to Plaintiffs;

(g) Where appropriate, a constructive trust or equitable lien over identifiable money, receivables, copyright or publishing interests, royalty participations, and other property obtained through Covered Exploitations;

(h) An order requiring Perry to correct, and to join in correcting, copyright registrations, performing rights organization registrations and works records, publishing-administration records, and related third-party records to reflect Plaintiffs' interests, and to direct payors to remit Plaintiffs' shares accordingly;

(i) Preliminary and permanent injunctive relief under 15 U.S.C. § 1116 and Tennessee common law barring Perry and those acting with him from using or licensing Plaintiffs' names, likenesses, or goodwill in a manner likely to cause confusion regarding source, affiliation, sponsorship, or approval, or from falsely representing that Perry may authorize such use;

(j) Perry's profits attributable to the unauthorized use of Plaintiffs' names, Plaintiffs' actual damages, and costs under 15 U.S.C. § 1117(a) and Tennessee common law;

(k) Corrective relief, including delivery up and destruction of infringing packaging, artwork, advertising, and promotional material under 15 U.S.C. § 1118;

(l) Punitive damages to the extent permitted by law;

(m) Costs, prejudgment and post-judgment interest, and attorneys' fees to the extent authorized by law; and

(n) Such other relief as the Court deems just and proper.

DEMAND FOR JURY TRIAL

Plaintiffs demand a trial by jury on all issues so triable.

Dated: September 28, 2026

Respectfully submitted,

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VERIFICATION

I, Christy Coran p/k/a “Gangsta Gold”, declare under penalty of perjury that the foregoing is true and correct.

_____

Christy Coran p/k/a “Gangsta Gold”
Executed on: 25/09/2026

VERIFICATION

I, Latonya Pierce p/k/a “MC Money”, declare under penalty of perjury that the foregoing is true and correct.

_____

Latonya Pierce p/k/a “MC Money”
Executed on: 25/09/2026